

DIRECT BOOKING & GUEST MANAGEMENT FOR VACATION-RENTAL OWNERS

Familiar Guest: the trust layer for an owner's own guests

A private booking and guest-management platform that lets individual vacation-property owners take direct bookings from their repeat and trusted guests — with payments, rental agreements, escrow, and cross-border tax handling built in.

Owners on Airbnb and VRBO lose ~15% of every booking and never own the guest relationship. Familiar Guest flips that: the booking page carries **the owner's property name**, the guest list belongs to the owner, and trust (escrow + verification) is on by default. Our brand stays invisible — we are the **infrastructure**, not the marketplace.

What it is — and is not

It is

- **Owner-first.** Built for individual/casual owners, not professional property managers.
- **Relationship-led.** For repeat and trusted guests, not stranger discovery.
- **Invisible infrastructure.** The owner's brand fronts every booking.
- **Trust by default.** Escrow, owner verification, optional guest screening.

It is not

- **Not a marketplace.** No discovery feed, no competing for visibility.
- **Not for portfolios.** Capped at 10 properties per owner — deliberately.
- **Not an OTA scraper.** Calendar sync via iCal only; owner-provided content only.
- **Not a tax advisor.** We handle and report; owners keep their own pros.

Positioning pillars

- ▶ **Effortless setup.** An owner is live in under an afternoon — minutes, not days.
- ▶ **Keep the earnings.** 5% PAYG or a flat monthly plan — no 15% platform cut.
- ▶ **Keep the relationship.** A private guest CRM the owner owns and re-invites each season.
- ▶ **Cross-border native.** Multi-currency, bilingual, snowbird long-stays, remote ops.

Beachhead (June 2026): US & Canadian owners who rent homes in Mexico — the **Todos Santos · Los Cabos · La Paz** corridor in Baja California Sur. These owners typically run **2+ units**, already have returning guests, and feel cross-border payment, trust, and tax pain most acutely. The product edge for them is the cross-border stack below.

THE FEATURE SET — ONBOARDING, TRUST & THE BOOKING

Getting an owner live, safely

Owner onboarding — two gates, two capability levels

GATE	WHAT IT UNLOCKS	HOW IT WORKS
Gate 1 Identity	Required for all owners. Unlocks Trusted-Guest Mode — send booking links to known guests and collect payment.	Stripe Connect Custom with embedded/hosted verification. Most owners clear in minutes. Sensitive KYC never touches our servers.
Gate 2 Ownership	Required only to list publicly. Unlocks Public Mode — escrow + booking guarantee + the Verified Owner badge.	One ownership document in the owner's name (deed, tax statement, fideicomiso for MX). Lightweight manual review at launch.

Hard gate: no owner may list a property or collect payment before Stripe identity verification completes — no exceptions, no workarounds.

Two booking modes

Trusted-guest mode is the core, low-bar use case: a private booking link to a known guest, no marketplace listing required. **Public mode** is the expansion path — accept stranger bookings with escrow, guarantee, and optional screening once ownership is verified.

The guest booking flow

A guest receives a private link — **no account hurdle, mobile-first** — and sees dates, a transparent fee breakdown (now a **daily rate × nights + cleaning fee**), the Verified-Owner badge, the rental agreement, and a payment summary. Funds are held in escrow until check-in; the damage deposit is held separately and released automatically after an inspection window.

Trust & safeguards — lead with these in UX

- **Escrow.** Guest funds held until check-in via Stripe delayed payout — the single most important consumer-trust feature. Never described as a regulated trust; FG never takes fund custody.
- **Verified Owner badge.** Every owner is identity-verified via Stripe KYC as a condition of payout.
- **Rental agreement.** Auto-generated per booking (DocuSeal), signed digitally before payment clears, stored permanently. Bilingual EN/ES with a governing-law clause keyed to the home's country.
- **Property verification.** Ownership document gates public-listing mode and awards the badge.

Compliance is a feature, not an afterthought. No Airbnb/OTA scraping (iCal sync only). No storage of SSNs or government IDs (Stripe handles KYC). No fund release before check-in without owner instruction. Verification works for non-US persons (passport / INE / CURP / RFC / fideicomiso). These are hard constraints baked into the design.

THE FEATURE SET — RELATIONSHIP, MONEY & CROSS-BORDER

The moat: the owner's guest relationship

Guest CRM — the core moat

A private guest directory the owner owns and never shares: contact, stay history, notes, preferences. Trust tiers (**vett****ed** / **returning** / **referral**) drive different booking rules. **One-click re-invite** at season end, **one-click rebook** ("same dates next year?"), and a **referral system** where a trusted guest's link pre-vets the new guest by association.

Messaging & house manual

Automated, multi-channel (SMS, WhatsApp, email — owner/guest choice), bilingual: booking confirmation, pre-arrival info, day-of check-in (with a **Google Maps GPS link** — required because Mexican street addresses are unreliable), optional mid-stay, checkout, and deposit-release. A private **digital house manual** (WiFi, codes, rules, local tips) is set once and delivered forever.

The cross-border differentiators

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES
Multi-currency + payouts	Price in USD/CAD/MXN; owner chooses payout currency and destination bank. FX passed at cost (a modest transparent spread is a planned future revenue line).
Bilingual + AI translation	EN/ES booking pages and two-way translated guest messaging.
Long-stay + installments	Weekly/monthly rates and deposit-now / balance-later for snowbird stays.
Remote-owner ops	Scoped caretaker/cleaner login (no payments, no full guest list) + digital check-in via lockbox/smart codes.
Income & Tax Accounting	The standout no competitor offers. Lodging-tax line items (US TOT / MX ISH/IVA), Mexican host-tax withholding to SAT where FG is platform-of-record, and tax-ready exports (Schedule E, MX filings) consolidated across units. Handling + reporting — never advice.

Pricing model

PLAN	PRICE	FOR
Pay-as-you-go	5% + processing	No monthly; the acquisition front door (first month commission-free, no card).
Starter	\$15/mo	One property, no commission.
Host	\$29/mo	Up to 5 properties — the likely modal plan for the 2+-unit beachhead.
Pro	\$49/mo	6–10 properties + consolidated reporting + priority support.

All plans carry payment-processing and FX fees, passed through at cost (net-zero to FG). Trust and money-movement features are never paywalled — plans differ only on commission-vs-flat, property count, and reporting. Calendar sync is iCal-based (15–30 min inbound refresh) with a visible "last synced" timestamp.

HOW IT WAS CREATED — STACK, DECISIONS & METHOD

A solo founder, building with AI

Familiar Guest is built by a single founder with professional developer and product-management experience, using AI-assisted tooling (**Claude Code, Cursor**) to compress what would traditionally take a small team. There are no full-time hires until unit economics justify it; a **\$5,000 budget** is reserved for expert contract review of the safety-critical money paths.

The stack — decided, deliberate

LAYER	CHOICE	WHY
Frontend / hosting	Next.js (App Router) on Vercel	Fast iteration; deploy straight from GitHub.
Database / auth	Supabase (Postgres)	Auth, storage, and edge functions in one managed layer.
Payments	Stripe Connect Custom	Maximum insulation — owners feel "Familiar Guest pays me," Stripe invisible.
Email / messaging	Resend · Twilio	Transactional email; SMS + WhatsApp for reminders.
Agreements / screening	DocuSeal · Truvi	E-signatures; guest screening that covers US <i>and</i> Mexico.
Calendar	iCal (.ics)	Standard, compliant, zero per-platform dev — no OTA APIs.

The decisions that shaped the build

Stripe Connect Custom over Standard

Custom accounts keep the Stripe brand fully out of the owner's experience and let Stripe own KYC, payout banking, and fund-holding compliance — so FG never stores SSNs or ID documents and never takes fund custody (avoiding money-transmitter licensing). The trade-off FG accepts: owning owner support, payout timing, and disputes.

iCal-only calendar sync

A hard compliance line — no scraping Airbnb/VRBO. Two one-way iCal feeds (not real-time), with a visible "last synced" timestamp so owners understand the double-booking window honestly.

Compliance-driven data model

Key entities — *owners, properties, listings, guests, bookings, agreements, calendar_feeds, payouts, screening_results* — are shaped by the constraints first: minimize PII, gate capabilities behind verification, and keep escrow hold/release auditable. Multi-jurisdiction privacy (LFPDPPP, GDPR, CCPA/CPRA, PIPEDA) is designed in, not retrofitted.

HOW IT WAS CREATED — SEQUENCE, SAFETY & STATUS

The MVP build sequence

- 1 **Marketing site** + waitlist capture — live on Vercel at famguest.com.
- 2 **Owner auth & onboarding** — Supabase Auth (email + magic link, Google/Apple), Stripe Connect Custom + embedded KYC.
- 3 **Property creation** — listing form, photo upload (cloud OAuth + drag-drop + mobile), AI-written descriptions.
- 4 **iCal calendar sync** — inbound feeds, generated outbound feed, last-synced status.
- 5 **Booking page** — branded, guest-facing, works without a guest account.
- 6 **Payments & escrow** — payment intents, escrow hold, deposit, webhook-driven check-in release.
- 7 **Rental agreement** — DocuSeal auto-generate + stored signed copy.
- 8 **Guest CRM & messaging** — directory + automated bilingual sequence.
- 9 **Guest screening** add-on, then **one-click rebook + referrals**.

Built with guardrails

Feature branches off a protected **main**; secrets in env vars (never committed); a staging environment and Stripe test mode until stable. Every Stripe webhook is signature-verified, logged, and idempotent. Guest-facing errors are mapped to friendly copy — raw Stripe/Supabase errors never reach the booking page. Accessibility is a requirement: keyboard-navigable, screen-reader-friendly (guests include older and non-technical users).

Reserved for expert review (\$5,000)

The safety-critical paths get an experienced engineer's eyes before production: **Stripe webhook handling** (silent-failure risk), **escrow hold-and-release timing**, **Connect negative-balance & fraud liability**, **security hardening**, and **ownership-document storage**.

Status (June 2026): The site is live on famguest.com. Owner accounts, multi-property portal, calendar, public listings, request-to-book, and the pay-by-link booking flow are **live in production** — including escrow-style delayed payout, Airbnb iCal conflict checks, daily-rate + cleaning-fee pricing, and guest payment confirmation by email or SMS. Next up: deepening the cross-border tax accounting and bilingual messaging, gated on Mexican counsel before any live MX payment-of-record flows.

Open items flagged for counsel before owner-facing claims: Mexican digital-platform tax withholding (ISR/IVA/SAT registration), the legal wrapper for MX e-signatures (NOM-151), and fideicomiso/restricted-zone ownership documents. Tax features ship phased — line items + withholding + exports first.